

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 3 2
♥ A 8 7 3
♦ 9 7 4
♣ J 10 2

♠ K Q J 5

♥ K 10

♦ A 8 3

♣ A 9 6 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 8 4

♥ 6 5 2

♦ K Q J 10 5

♣ K 8

♠ A 7 6

♥ Q J 9 4

♦ 6 2

♣ Q 7 5 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♦ K			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♦ K, dummy plays the ♦ 2 and West the ♦ 4.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 6

You need 3 more winners, and they must come from the ♥ suit. The danger is that when you knock out the ♥ A, East may take too many ♦ s.

East continues with the ♦ Q; dummy plays the ♦ 6 and West the ♦ 7.

East continues with the ♦ J; dummy discards the ♣ 3 and West plays the ♦ 9.

You held up your ♦ A until the third round to exhaust West of ♦ s.

Next you start on ♥ s by playing ♥ K, then overtaking the ♥ 10. Assume that West wins the second ♥ .

You were fortunate it was West who took the ♥ A, and that he has no ♦ to return. If he plays a ♥ or a ♠ you will win in dummy. If he plays a ♣ you will jump up with the ♣ A and take your winners, 9 in all.

You were lucky the ♥ A was with West.

But if you had not held-up your ♦ A even good luck wouldn't have helped you.

Board 2

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q J 10 5

♥ J 10

♦ 9 6 2

♣ J 7 6

♠ A 7 6

♥ A 8 6 5 3

♦ K 5

♣ A K 5



♠ 9 4 3

♥ Q 9 7 2

♦ A 8 4

♣ Q 10 2

♠ 8 2

♥ K 4

♦ Q J 10 7 3

♣ 9 8 4 3

West

North

East

South

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♠ K

1 ♥

Pass

1NT

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠ K.

East follows with the ♠ 3 and you play the ♠ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 5

Even if ♥s split 3-3 you could only get 2 extra winners there, so it should be clear that you must establish the ♦s. You will have to drive out the ♦ A and hope they don't win too many ♠s at that time.

West continues with the ♠ Q.

East follows with the ♠ 4 and you play the ♠ 8. West continues with the ♠ J.

East follows with the ♠ 9 and you discard the ♣ 3. Holding up the ♠ A until the third round helps your chances.

Having just taken the third ♠ trick you now work on ♦s by first playing the ♦ K, then continuing the suit. East wins the third one with his ♦ A. And now the good news - he has no ♠ left to reach his partner's good tricks. So East plays the ♥ Q.

At this point in the play you have three tricks in the bank; ♠ A, ♦ K, ♦ Q. You take your ♥ K, cash the two good ♦s, then lead to dummy for the ♣ A K and ♥ A. Voila!

You were lucky that East had the ♦ A since he only had 3 ♠s.

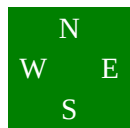
But what if East actually held 4 ♠s? No problem, in that case the ♠s would have split 4-4 so the defenders could only win 3 ♠ tricks and the ♦ A.

The hold-up lets you make the contract whenever East holds the ♦ A. And if West happened to hold the ♦ A??? You go down.

Board 3
 South Deals
 E-W Vul

♠ A 8 6
 ♥ Q J 9 2
 ♦ K 7 4
 ♣ 9 7 3

♠ K 9 4
 ♥ A 6 3
 ♦ Q J 8 2
 ♣ A Q 4



♠ Q J 7 3 2
 ♥ 10 7
 ♦ 6 5
 ♣ J 10 8 2

♠ 10 5
 ♥ K 8 5 4
 ♦ A 10 9 3
 ♣ K 6 5

West	North	East	South
			Pass
Pass	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♠3			

♦K.

It's too bad the finesse didn't work, but it's not too too bad! Because West is out of ♠s and must lead one of the other suits. You don't care which he leads because you can now win 8 more tricks and make your contract.

As long as you were going to finesse into West you could establish the ♦s without allowing East to gain the lead.

And as long as you had held up on the ♠K until the third round you could ensure that West was out of ♠s if he had started with only 3.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠3. West wins the first trick with the ♠A and returns the ♠8.

East plays the ♠Q and dummy the ♠10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You can win 3 more ♦ tricks if the finesse works, but even if it doesn't work you can still get the 2 that you need. Of course if West does win the ♦K it would sure be great if he had no ♠ to lead.

East continues with the ♠J; dummy discards a ♥ and West plays the ♠6.

You ducked the second ♠ and took your ♠K on the third round.

After winning the ♠K you are conveniently in your hand, so you play the ♦Q and let it ride when East plays a low card. Alas, West takes the trick with his

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 4
 ♥ 6 5 4 2
 ♦ K Q J 4
 ♣ 7 5

♠ Q 6
 ♥ A 10 9
 ♦ 7 5 2
 ♣ K J 10 6 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 9 3 2
 ♥ Q 8 3
 ♦ 10 9 6
 ♣ A Q 3

♠ A K 7 5
 ♥ K J 7
 ♦ A 8 3
 ♣ 9 8 2

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♦ K			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ K, dummy plays the ♦ 2 and East the ♦ 6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 6

You will need some ♣ tricks to make the contract. If West has 5 ♦s and also the ♣A then you will go down. It doesn't matter if he has the ♣Q because you can finesse him out of that.

But in the case where East has both the ♣ A Q you need to make sure he has no ♦ when he takes his first trick.

West continues with the ♦ Q; dummy plays the ♦ 5 and East the ♦ 9.

West continues with the ♦ J; dummy plays the ♦ 7 and East the ♦ 10.

You held up the ♦ A until the third round, everybody following.

Now start on the ♣s. Play your ♣9 and let it ride. East wins the ♣Q and returns a ♠. Good, he didn't have the fourth ♦.

Win with dummy's ♠Q and force out the ♣A.

The rest of the tricks are yours, nine in all.

If East had only held 2 ♦s it would have been OK to hold up your ♦ A just once.

But with this layout you needed to hold up twice.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K 7 5 3

♥ J 9

♦ J 8 5 2

♣ Q 10 4

♠ J 10 9 4

♥ K Q 2

♦ A K 9

♣ K 7 6



♠ 6

♥ A 10 8 6 4

♦ 10 7 3

♣ J 8 3 2

♠ A Q 8 2

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 6 4

♣ A 9 5

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥6

it ride. West wins their third trick with the ♠K but has no ♥ to return so he plays a ♦ which you win with your ♦A.

Play off your 7 winners and give up a ♣ at the end.

The K Q x holding is similar to the A J x holding. It might be two stoppers, or might just be one, depending on which defender next leads the suit.

So you decide whether to hold up or not based on how you expect to play the hand.

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution South chooses not to bother with Stayman. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥3 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if East takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if West takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into West you should hold up.

West returns the ♥9, East takes the ♥A and clears the suit.

You have lost two tricks so far. Lead the ♠J and let

Board 6

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K 3
 ♥ A 10 8 6 4
 ♦ 10 7 3
 ♣ J 8 3

♠ J 10 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ A K 9

♣ A 9 5



♠ 7 6 5
 ♥ J 9
 ♦ J 8 5 2
 ♣ Q 10 4 2

♠ A Q 8 2

♥ K Q 2

♦ Q 6 4

♣ K 7 6

West	North	East	South
			1NT

Pass 3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥6

he will probably exit with a ♣ which you take with the ♣K.

Play off your 6 winners and concede the last three tricks.

This was almost the same as Deal 5, the difference being in which direction the ♠ finesse had to be taken.

But it sure makes a big difference in how you play the hand.

This might have turned out even better. If West had decided to play his partner for the ♥Q, (who would have played ♥J from a holding of ♥ Q J x), you would have made an overtrick!

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution North chooses not to bother with Stayman. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥3 and East the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if West takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if East takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into West you should not hold up.

You win with your ♥K, (keeping West in the dark about who holds the ♥Q), enter dummy with the ♦A and play the ♠J, letting it ride to West's ♠K.

West cannot play ♥s without setting up your ♥Q so

Board 7

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ J 6

♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6

♦ 10 6 2

♣ 4

♠ A 9 2

♥ A 9 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ A Q 7 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K Q 10 8 3

♥ 4

♦ J 8 7 3

♣ K 5 2

♠ 7 5 4

♥ 5 3

♦ A 9 5

♣ J 10 9 8 3

West

3♥

North

3NT

East

South

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥4

is no need to hold up. But . . . it couldn't hurt, could it?

Yes, it could hurt real bad! Suppose West has nothing in his hand but the ♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6 that you already know about. When you let his ♥10 win the first trick he will realize that his hand is dead. And he may be smart enough, (or lucky enough), to switch to a ♠.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. So the general guideline is to hold up until you are sure one of the defenders is void in the suit - maybe twice, maybe only once, and in this case not at all.

But one of the important considerations you have to think about is the possibility that the Defense will switch to another suit - where you might be in even more trouble.

You'd feel bad on this hand if you let West hold the ♥10 only to see him next lay down the ♠J.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥4, dummy plays the ♥3 and West the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 6

You may not agree with North's 3NT bid but how else are you going to get to the only game that has a chance of making?

You need 3 extra winners and they will come from the ♣ suit even if East holds the ♣K and wins your finesse. You may think about holding up on the ♥A for one round just to make sure East has none if he wins the ♣K.

That would be a mistake. It is almost certain that West has a 7-card ♥ suit for his preemptive opening. This is confirmed by East's lead of the ♥4, with a doubleton he would have led a higher card. So there

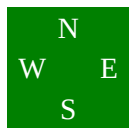
Board 8

East Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 3
 ♥ J 9 5 4
 ♦ 8 7 3
 ♣ Q 7 4 2

♠ Q 10 6 2
 ♥ K 7 6
 ♦ A Q J 9
 ♣ 9 5



♠ 4
 ♥ A Q 10 2
 ♦ K 6 4
 ♣ K 10 8 6 3

♠ A K J 8 7 5
 ♥ 8 3
 ♦ 10 5 2
 ♣ A J

West	North	East	South
		1 ♣	1 ♠
Pass	2 ♣	Pass	4 ♠
All Pass			
4 ♠ by South			
Lead: ♣2			

North's 2 ♣ cue-bid shows a limit-raise or better in ♠s. South is to play 4 ♠. West leads the ♣2, dummy plays the ♣5 and East the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You have one loser too many. If West holds either the ♥A or the ♦K this will be an easy contract, but East opened the bidding so he probably has most of the high cards. It does look like West holds the ♣Q based on his low lead and East's play to trick one.

Having gone through that thought process what is your Plan?

You will need to discard a loser on dummy's fourth ♦, but you must do so without ever letting West gain the lead since West is the defender who can lead through dummy's ♥K. And the only card that West can get the lead with is the ♣Q.

Hold-ups are usually used in notrump hands, but here you use one to prevent the Danger Hand from gaining the lead. Let East have the ♣K. He cannot play a red card without helping you so he will surely play another ♣.

Pull trumps in two rounds. Then play the ♦10 and let it ride.

East will win this but he is helpless. Whatever he plays you will be able to discard a ♥ loser on dummy's ♦.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. Here you knew you would lose exactly one ♣ trick so you chose to lose it to East, the Safe Hand.

If you had taken the first ♣ trick East would have won your later ♦ finesse, put his partner on lead with the ♣Q and then swallowed up your ♥K.

Of course if West had been clever enough to lead a ♥ originally this Deal wouldn't be here.

Board 9

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A 8 3

♥ Q J 10 6 4 2

♦ 7 3

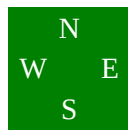
♣ 4 2

♠ K J 7

♥ A 9 5

♦ J 10 9 2

♣ A K 10



♠ Q 10 6

♥ K 8

♦ K Q 6 5

♣ 8 7 5 3

♠ 9 5 4 2

♥ 7 3

♦ A 8 4

♣ Q J 9 6

West

2♥

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥7

North

2NT

East

Pass

South

3NT

North's 2NT overcall shows a 1NT opening hand with ♥s stopped. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥7.

West plays the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You will need to establish both ♠ and ♦ winners. If West holds both these Aces along with 6 ♥s to the Q J then you are going down. But of course West can't have that good a hand, he opened with a Weak-2. So East has one of the Aces.

If you knew which Ace West held you could make sure you attacked that suit first but unfortunately you have no way of knowing that. So instead you resort to a hold-up.

West continues with the ♥Q.

East follows with the ♥3.

You let West have the first ♥ and won the next ♥ in dummy.

Start on ♦s next, maybe because they are longer. Assume that East holds the ♦A and takes it on the third round of the suit.

East glares at you, (because he has no ♥ to lead), and plays the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A. Next you score your ♦ winners and play a ♠, taken by West with the ♠A.

West glares at you, (because you still have the ♥A), and plays another ♥.

You take your 3 tricks and let East have the last ♣.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♦s first you would not have made the contract.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♠s first you would have made the contract even though you played incorrectly.

If you held up on the first trick you made the contract no matter which Ace East held.

Board 10

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 4 3
 ♥ K Q 10 9 5
 ♦ Q 4
 ♣ 10 5 2

♠ A Q 6

♥ 8 4 2

♦ 7 6 5 2

♣ K Q 3



♠ J 10 8 7

♥ 6

♦ K J 10 9

♣ J 9 8 4

♠ K 5 2

♥ A J 7 3

♦ A 8 3

♣ A 7 6

West	North	East	South
			1NT

Pass 3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥K

continue, just what you want.

Sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn't.

I sure hope that when you play this hand West falls for your Bath Coup.

Because if he doesn't you're going to have to end-play him.

Do you see how that might happen?

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and East the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You just need one more winner and it could come from the ♦ suit if it happens to split 3-3. But you have another possibility. Suppose you let West hold the first trick and he decides to play another ♥? You would have two ♥ winners.

This isn't a true hold-up play although it does look like one. This play has the rather fancy name of Bath Coup, (named from Bath, England). Presumably West has led from ♥ K Q 10 9 5 and East has played his singleton ♥6. If West realizes that East has played his lowest card he will take that as a discouraging signal and will play a different suit. So you throw out your ♥7 rather than the ♥3. Now West may think that East is encouraging him to

Board 11

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 7 3
♥ K 6 4 3
♦ K 7 3 2
♣ 5 2

♠ Q 8 4

♥ A 7 2

♦ A J 8

♣ K J 8 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 5

♥ J 10 9 8

♦ 9 6 4

♣ 10 3

♠ 9 6 2

♥ Q 5

♦ Q 10 5

♣ A Q 9 7 4

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥J

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You try dummy's ♥Q but West plays the ♥K.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=5 Total = 7

Things do not look good. You have only one ♥ stopper, the ♠ suit is wide open, and you have to have the ♦ finesse to get the two extra winners you need.

First problem: Do you hold up the ♥A or not?

No, don't hold up. If you do they might take 4 ♠ tricks immediately, then go back to ♥s. Since your only hope of making this contract is the ♦ finesse you should grab the ♥A, play 5 rounds of ♣s then finesse for the ♦K.

Or not.

Remember: don't hold up when it gives the defenders a good opportunity to switch.

Board 12

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 6 3
♥ K J 9 6 3
♦ 8 4 2
♣ Q 9

♠ Q 7 4

♥ 8 5

♦ K J 10 3

♣ 7 5 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 10 8 2

♥ Q 10 4

♦ 9 7

♣ A 10 8 3

♠ A K 5

♥ A 7 2

♦ A Q 6 5

♣ K J 6

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
			2NT

Pass 3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥6

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥5 and East the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=0 Total = 8

You need only one more winner.

East returns the ♥10.

West wins with the ♥J and continues with the ♥3; dummy discards a ♣ and East plays the ♥4.

Needing only one more winner, you held up on the first ♥ and on the continuation, taking your ♥A on the third round.

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when East plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when East plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

This is not a guess. If West has the ♣A he will get the lead and when he does he will set you with 2 more ♥ tricks. So you assume that East has the ♣A and play your ♣K.

This is a lesson about holding up, and if you had not held up twice in ♥s you would certainly have gone down.

But it's not enough to just be smart enough to hold up, you must also be able to figure out how to make the best plays later as well.

Board 13

North Deals

Both Vul

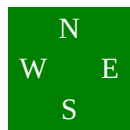
♠ 7 4
 ♥ 9 6 5
 ♦ K 9 6 2
 ♣ Q J 10 9

♠ A J 10 8 5 2

♥ K J 4

♦ A 8

♣ K 6



♠ K 6

♥ 8 7 3

♦ Q J 10 4

♣ A 8 3 2

♠ Q 9 3

♥ A Q 10 2

♦ 7 5 3

♣ 7 5 4

West	North	East	South
	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			

4 ♠ by North

Lead: ♦ Q

you a trick. Whatever else he plays you win, pull trumps, and discard a ♣ loser on dummy's fourth ♥.

At notrump you usually hold up to exhaust one player of a suit so he cannot lead that suit back to his partner.

At suit contracts the most common reason for a hold-up is to keep the Danger Hand from getting the lead.

North is to play 4 ♠. East leads the ♦ Q, dummy plays the ♦ 3 and West the ♦ 9.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 4

On the plus side dummy has an extra ♥ winner on which you could discard a loser from your hand. The danger is that when you take the trump finesse, East might win the ♠ K and put his partner in the lead with the ♦ K for a ♣ play through your ♣ K.

To prevent that from happening all you have to do is hold up on the first ♦. You have to lose one trick in the suit no matter what, so lose it right now to East, the Safe Hand. East continues with another ♦ which you win.

You go over to dummy with a ♥ and play the ♠ Q, letting it ride. East wins with his ♠ K, but cannot play ♣s from his side of the table without handing

Board 14

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 7 6 3
 ♥ K Q 10 8 5
 ♦ K 10 9
 ♣ 7 2

♠ K Q 9

♥ A 3 2

♦ 7 5 3

♣ Q 9 5 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 10 5 2

♥ 9 6

♦ A J 6 2

♣ 10 8 3

♠ A 8 4

♥ J 7 4

♦ Q 8 4

♣ A K J 6

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥K			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥K.

East plays the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 8

Unless there is a miracle in the ♦s, (or a defensive error), you can't get a trick in that suit. But you have a chance for a second ♥ trick.

It's the Bath Coup again, just dressed up a little differently.

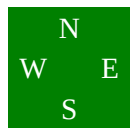
Let West hold the first trick, playing the ♥7 from your hand to conceal the ♥4 in the hope that West will continue the suit. If he does you have your ninth trick - if he doesn't, good luck.

Compare this Bath Coup to the one in Deal 10.

Board 15
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q 4
♥ Q J 9 8
♦ J 8 6 2
♣ 8 7 2

♠ 10 9 5 3
♥ A K 4
♦ A Q 7
♣ K 6 3



♠ K J 8 7 2
♥ 10 7 5
♦ 10 9 4
♣ A 5

♠ A 6
♥ 6 3 2
♦ K 5 3
♣ Q J 10 9 4

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass
3NT by North
Lead: ♠ 7

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠ 7.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=3 ♣=0 Total = 6

It's pretty clear that your extra tricks are going to have to come from the ♣ suit. The danger here is that East may have a 5-card ♠ suit that he can establish and the ♣A as an entry. So what is the best approach, hold up or not hold up?

To answer that question you must think about East's lead. Since he did not lead the ♠K you know he doesn't have a suit headed by K Q J. So you can visualize West sitting there with a doubleton honor in ♠s. It might be ♠ K x, ♠ Q x or ♠ J x, but it is surely one of those three.

Think what West will do if you duck in dummy. He will play his honor, win the trick, and clear the suit

by leading his small x. If East can get in with the ♣A he will run the ♠s.

But what will West do if you play dummy's ♠ A? If he plays his small one the ♠ suit will block. If he unblocks his honor card then your ♠ 10 9 5 3 will provide a second stopper in the suit. So you go up with dummy's ♠ A and guarantee the contract.

A tough finish that needs some real visualization to get right.

Of course from now on you will recognize it.